

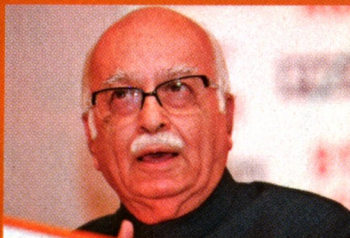
candidature since that will leave the post of leader of the opposition vacant for him once Advani steps down. Rajnath has managed to convince most party leaders about Jaitley's unsuitability, projecting him as a city slicker with no national appeal. Advani, however, continues to hope that his protégé Jaitley will make it to the top party post at a time when it is ready for a major organisational and ideological overhaul. Swaraj is also using her post of the deputy leader of the opposition to garner maximum support by the end of the year when the organisational election takes place. Projecting herself as a unifier, she is not only giving floor time to as many MPs as possible but reaching out to disgruntled veterans like Jaswant Singh and Yashwant Sinha. For instance, 54 party MPs got a chance to speak on the Railway budget.

Hers is not an easy task, considering the number of senior party leaders who have made it to the House this time. Leaders like Jaswant Singh, Yashwant Sinha, Murli Manohar Joshi, Rajnath Singh and Shatrughan Sinha have come from the Rajya Sabha to the Lok Sabha. From front-row seats on Opposition benches to membership to various standing committees of the House, the demands of MPs know no bounds. They also want to open debates and speak on important issues. Swaraj has so many inflated egos to take care of. And she is doing a fine job. Yashwant Sinha, the party's most articulate voice on business and economy, was denied the chance to open the debate on the Budget. She later pacified him by asking him to take the lead on the joint statement. He vindicated himself by putting forward a strong nationalist argument that the treasury benches found hard to counter. Disillusioned with the ways of an insensitive party, he was not sure till a day earlier if he would actually get to open the debate.

The BJP has become a party of cabals and an organisation that banishes dissent. Only points raised by certain speakers in both the Houses are issued as press statements. The privileged include Jaitley, Ananth

Split Wide Open

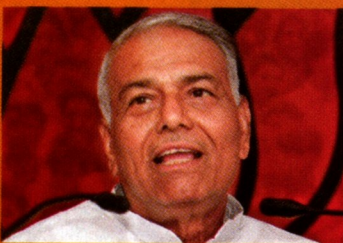
Parliament session has laid bare the sharp lines dividing the BJP



LAL KRISHNA ADVANI

Leader of the Opposition, Lok Sabha

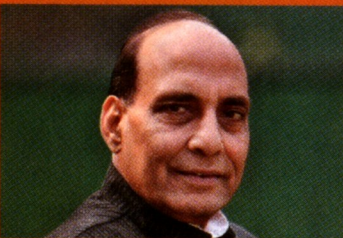
Would like to see Jaitley as the party president even as he grooms Swaraj to take over his post in the Lok Sabha once he steps down.



YASHWANT SINHA

Senior BJP Leader

Denied the chance to speak on the Budget, the sulking dissenter finally led the debate on the Indo-Pak joint statement.



RAJNATH SINGH

BJP President

Aspires to be the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha and supports Swaraj's candidature for party president.

Kumar, Ravi Shankar Prasad and Venkaiah Naidu in the Rajya Sabha; and Advani, Swaraj and Rajnath in the Lok Sabha. Initially, leaders were even squabbling over seating arrangements in Lok Sabha, elbowing out each other for a spot of prominence. It was Swaraj's intervention that ensured second row seats to carping MPs like Gopinath Munde and Shahnawaz Hussain, who found another reason to be miffed when he was not allowed to open the debate on the Railway Budget. Kumar got the chance. A disgruntled Hussain did not speak; he tabled his speech.

Swaraj may project herself as a leader who wants to establish internal democracy. In practice, she is a me-first diva. Even as she has proposed to get senior disgruntled leaders Yashwant Sinha and Jaswant Singh on the much sought after Public Accounts Committee (PAC) along with party General Secretary Gopinath Munde, she herself wants to be the chairman of Committee on External Affairs. To be fair, Jaswant Singh should have been asked to chair the PAC. Also, she got herself elected to the governing body of the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), much to the chagrin of party colleague Shatrughan Sinha, who thought he should have been given a chance since he has been health minister. But so has been Swaraj. The Congress got first-time MP Jyoti Mirdha, a qualified doctor, elected to the second seat on the prestigious AIIMS body.

The never-ending tussle within the party will be played out next in the "chintan baithak" on from August 17 to 19 in Mumbai. A report analysing its debacle in the Lok Sabha elections by BJP Vice-President Bal Apte is to be discussed during at the meet. The party wants to limit the guest list to 30-35 and is busy working out the criteria. Efforts are on to find a way of keeping articulate conscience keepers like Yashwant Sinha and Arun Shourie out. Well, the party with a difference can no longer tolerate leaders with a different point of view. ■